The Theological DNA of Redeemer Global

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INTRODUCTION

The mission of Redeemer Global

The great global cities are the key to the course of world culture, but no Christian movement is reaching central cities on any kind of scale. God, by His grace, has allowed ***Redeemer Church*** in New York City to become unusually effective in bringing center city residents to believe and live the gospel of Christ.

Redeemer Global is dedicated to scaling and *contextualizing* Redeemer Church's ministry assets into a global movement. Its mission is to multiply churches and both church and cultural leaders throughout the center-cities of the world who work out of the theological vision and gospel ministry model that we have found so effective in New York.

The gospel ministry strategy of Redeemer Global

In the major cities of the world, Redeemer Global will develop churches and leaders which, through the gospel, 1) ***connect*** people to God and each other, 2) ***serve*** and seek the welfare of the entire city, and 3) ***extend*** that ministry into cities through new churches and new leaders. This comprehensive strategy flows from our understanding of the gospel itself:

Gospel Summary Through the work of Christ on our behalf, God by grace rescues and draws men and women into fellowship with himself and one another, and restores the creation where we will enjoy this fellowship forever.

The importance of distinctives

One goal of Redeemer Global is to build an organic movement of churches, ministries, and individuals that will belong to many different Christian denominations and traditions. What will unite them? Agreement on the classic doctrines of the Scripture is absolutely necessary (see Part 2.) yet still insufficient for a dynamic movement. We must also know the movement's DNA--the distinctive theological *emphases* and strategic ministry *values* that will bind together all those who are part of it.

The DNA in each cell is essentially a set of instructions deep within an organism that a) directs how it develops and grows, and that b) makes it capable of self-replication. It is better to talk of DNA than 'philosophy of ministry' because Redeemer Global is much more theologically-driven than program-driven. This fits the organic imagery of DNA. Our emphases and values are deep and basic enough to unite us even though they may take sharply different form in different cultures and continents.

The use of the distinctives

Redeemer Global's distinctives come in two parts—1) DNA distinctives, and 2) Statements of Faith. The churches that we support and produce must be orthodox in Christian doctrine without exception, and our faith statements define this. All must subscribe to it. With regard to the DNA, however, we may take a more flexible approach. We believe that the various parts of the DNA are interwoven and imply one another. Therefore a church or leader who wants to work with us but has some reservations about some of the DNA would likely still be allowed to do so. Many church leaders will therefore feel they are very much in middle of our movement, that there is no other network of churches and leaders that better embodies their own understanding of Christian ministry. Others may happily work with us even though feeling they don't share all our priorities and expressions.

Part 1 – DNA Distinctives

The Five Values

Gospel-driven. – *A theologically rich way to read the Bible which makes the gospel the driving and shaping force of everything we do.*

Our main distinctive is our conviction about the depth and comprehensiveness of the gospel. We would never say that we 'have' the gospel in some way that the rest of the church does not. What makes us different is how comprehensively we *use* it. The gospel is not just a set of introductory truths but as the key to understanding every text of the Bible, to living and growing as a Christian at every point, and as a comprehensive perspective on all of life. The gospel must be worked into every corner of our thinking, feeling, and behavior. The gospel is our engine, driving all individual and corporate Christian practice. This theologically rich understanding of the gospel combines the strengths and avoids the limitations of many other movements and expressions in the church today. Ingredients within this value: **Gospel theology** and **Gospel renewal dynamics.**

City-focused. *–An effective and comprehensive model for engaging and changing culture through Christian living and service in cities.*

Our movement believes in the importance of the city—as the city goes, so goes the culture and society. While there must be Christians and churches everywhere there are people, the great cities of the world are underserved by the church and are the single most strategic place to live the Christian life and carry out ministry. The purpose of Christians in the city should not be so much to use the city to build great churches, but to use the resources of the church to seek a great, flourishing city. The church should be a distinct counter-culture (therefore able to relate to society prophetically) but one that is dedicated to the common good, which loves and serves the city around it. This dual approach, grounded in a positive theology of the city, strikes a path which is distinct from the other dominant Church-culture models operative today. Ingredients within this value: The **city-growth ministry model** and the **culture change model**

Ministry-balanced. – *A unique, integrative balance of four ministry areas: evangelism, community-formation, social justice, and the integration of faith and work.*

The four ministry areas of our churches flow out of our understanding of the gospel (see summary on page 1.) Evangelism and worship connect people to God, while community formation connects people to each other. Justice and mercy seeks the welfare of the city by working directly on the places that the social fabric is weak. The integration of faith and work teaches people to see their vocation not just as a means of individual fulfillment but as a way to serve God and the city. Our churches stress both the individual and corporate aspects of the church, both word and deed forms of ministry. We do not play them off against each other, but rather see them as inter-dependent. There are four ingredients within this value, and they are deeper looks at each of the ministry areas: Connecting people to God and each other through **evangelism and worship** and **community formation;** seeking the welfare of the city through **justice and service** and **the integration of faith and work.**

Outward-faced. *– A way to contextualize every part of a church's message and ministry so that it connects effectively with the non-Christian people in secular, pluralistic global center-cities.*

Most churches assume the presence of conservative, traditional people around who can rather simply be called to a decision in classic evangelistic venues. A "missional" church (as we define it) gears every single part of its life—its worship, community, public discourse, education, preaching—for the presence of non-believers who have various modern, 'post-modern,' and post-secular sensibilities. A missional church's gospel presentations enter and re-tell the culture's stories, showing their resolution in Jesus. A missional church assumes that Christianity will critique every culture and yet in every culture assumes forms to that society. The missional church gives non-Christians attractive glimpses of what they would look like as Christians. Ingredients within this value: **A missiological model for the church** and **contextualization**

Movement-minded. *– A commitment to the reproducing of new churches and leaders in global cities as the most strategic way to do missions today.*

Planting of new congregations is the single most crucial strategy for the growth of the Body of Christ and the impact of that body on the culture of any city. Church planting should not be an unusual occurrence. Rather, every church should always be planning for or doing church planting. The key to church planting, however, is a heavy emphasis on leadership development. Leadership training systems should be localized and both theologically and educationally sophisticated. Both church leaders (lay and ordained) and cultural leaders (who work on the peace and welfare of the city) must be identified and trained. The ingredients within this value are: **globalization and church planting** and **globalization and leadership development.**

The Twelve Ingredients

(GOSPEL-DRIVEN)

1. Gospel theology. The most theologically rich way to read the Bible is to read it *both* as a series of many stories, with many central figures, teaching many things *and* also as one great single story, with one hero, Jesus Christ, who comes to earth to nenew the world. Churches that read the Bible mainly in the first way tend to stress sound doctrine and right individual behavior. They recognize that salvation is by being converted through the new birth. They major in evangelism and discipleship. Churches that read the Bible mainly in the second way tend to stress belonging to a

new community and working for peace in the world. They recognize the goal of salvation as the restoration of creation. They major in social justice and cultural renewal. The churches in our movement We do both in an integrative way, and the resulting ministry is unique.

2. <u>Gospel renewal dynamics</u>. Deep change in individuals and churches comes through the dynamic of grace, rather than through moralistic striving or the mere application of techniques. The components of individual renewal dynamics are a) repenting for remaining forms of self-salvation and idols, b) gaining new levels of understanding of our identity in Christ, and c) deeper experience of fellowship with God in prayer. Components of corporate renewal dynamics are: a) corporate, kingdom-centered prayer, b) Christo-centric gospel preaching, c) prominent renewed individuals (both those in leadership and those who are newer believers or renewed believers.

(CITY-FOCUSED)

3. <u>A city-growth model of ministry</u>. A city growth model builds on a positive theology of the city, recognizing the importance of the city as the refuge of the weak, the cultural forge of a society, and an unmatched setting for evangelism. Our city-growth model understands the overall goal of a church is the flourishing of the whole city and the whole Body of Christ in the city, not just the growth of your church and tribe. Both churches and ministries, both church and cultural leaders, both word and deed--must be incorporated as much as possible into a cooperative matrix of urban parishes and agencies.

4. <u>A cultural change model</u>. Most churches have adopted one of he various historic approaches to relating the church to culture. Some stress the creation of an alternative, Christian counter-culture, marked by love, peace, and justice, rejecting any direct effort to influence society as a whole. Others also take the indirect approach, seeking to change things 'one heart at a time' through evangelism. Others take a more direct approach through political action. Others emphasize that Christians should apply their world-view to all areas of life. We believe that all of these approaches have Biblical warrant, but that it is a mistake to see any of them as the only right way or as an exclusive 'magic bullet.' Each church must craft a distinct approach to culture that combines these methods in ways that fit the gift-mix of the congregation and the particular state of the surrounding culture.

(MINISTRY-BALANCED)

5. <u>Worship and Evangelism</u>. We are churches that seek to be highly effective with skeptical people. Rather than simply confront contemptuously those who disbelieve, we sympathetically find ways to address baseline cultural hopes and aspirations with Christ and his saving work. Even our worship is *evangelistic* worship. We can do both deep edification of believers and effective evangelism in worship at the same time because the gospel of grace is always the main thing that everyone needs. What Christians need to grow is the application of the gospel to different points of need. But that is main thing non-believers need as well. So worship and preaching must present the gospel in a fresh way each week. Our worship also models to Christians how to articulate the gospel coherently in a secular, pluralistic culture.

6. <u>Community Formation</u> We seek to spiritually form people mainly through community. Growth in grace and wisdom and character does not happen so much in classes and instruction as in

deep family-relationships and in counter-cultural communities where sex, money, and power are used in unique and life-giving ways. Christian community is not simply a supportive fellowship but an alternate society. Because the gospel points us to a man who died for his enemies, the gospel creates relationships of service rather than of selfishness. Because the gospel calls us to holiness, the people of God live in loving bonds of mutual accountability and discipline. Because the gospel removes both fear and pride, people get along inside the church who could never get along outside. Thus the gospel creates a human community radically different from any society around it.

7. Justice and Service God created both soul and body, and the resurrection of Jesus shows that he is going to redeem both the spiritual and the material. Therefore God is not just concerned for the salvation of souls but also for the removal of poverty, hunger, and injustice. The gospel opens our eyes to the fact that all our wealth (even wealth we worked hard for) is ultimately an unmerited gift from God. The person, therefore, who does not generously give away his or her wealth to others is not merely lacking in compassion, but is unjust. Christian churches must work for justice and peace in their neighborhoods through service even as they call individuals to conversion and the new birth. We must work for the common good and show our neighbors we love them sacrificially whether they believe as we do or not. Indifference to the poor and disadvantaged means there has not been a true grasp of our salvation by sheer *grace*.

8. Integration of Faith and Work Our churches help their people integrate faith and work for cultural renewal**.** Many Christians 'seal off' their faith-beliefs from the way they work in their vocation. The gospel is seen as a means of finding individual peace and not as a 'world-view'-- a comprehensive interpretation of reality that affects all we do. But the gospel has a deep and vital impact on how we do art, business, government, media, and scholarship. We support Christians' engagement with culture, helping them work with excellence, distinctiveness, and accountability in their professions and in 'secular work.'

(OUTWARD-FACED)

9. A missiological model for the church We have a vision for a church that sees conversions of highly secular and postmodern people, rather than reaching only conservative and tradition-minded people. A missional church will be filled with members who winsomely address the current cultural hopes and aspirations with Christ and his saving work. Because of the attractiveness of its community and the humility of its people, a missional church will discover significant numbers of people in its midst who are exploring and trying to understand Christianity. It must welcome them in hundreds of ways. It will do little to make them 'comfortable' but will do everything to make its message understandable.

10. Contextualization Contextualization is adapting gospel ministry from one culture into another culture by a) changing those aspects of ministry that are culturally conditioned, and b) maintaining those aspects of ministry that are unchanging and Biblically required. It 'incarnates' the Christian faith in a particular culture. It is the process by which we present the gospel to people of a particular world-view, in forms that the hearers can understand. Contextualization is not 'giving people what they want' but rather it is giving God's answers (which they may not want!) to questions they are asking and in forms that they can comprehend. Everything about a church must

be contextualized—its message, its discourse, its approach to decision-making, its leadership approaches, its worship, its use of the arts, its outreach, its instructional methods, its preaching.

(MOVEMENT-MINDED)

11. Globalization and church planting How globalization makes reaching cities much more important. To be movement-minded means practicing the unity of the Body instead of only trying to see your own tribe increase.

12. Globalization and leadership development A Biblical theology of leadership. A plan for developing both church and cultural leaders both locally and globally. The importance of training as a vehicle for contextualization. The need for excellence in non-formal educational models.

A detailed outline of the values and ingredients

1. GOSPEL-DRIVEN. (See Appendix A)

- **A. Gospel theology.**
  - (1.) **Reading the Bible as individual stories from individual authors (synchronic)**
  - (2.) **Reading the Bible as one story about Christ (diachronic)**
- **B. Gospel renewal dynamics.**
  - (3.) **Individual renewal dynamics.**
  - (4.) **Corporate renewal dynamics and preaching.**

2. CITY-FOCUSED.

- **C. A city-growth ministry model.**
  - (5.) **Positive theology of the city**
  - (6.) **City-nets and the ministry matrix**
- **D. A cultural change model**
  - (7.) **A theology of culture**
  - (8.) **Balanced view and use of cultural models**

3. MINISTRY-BALANCED

- **E. Connecting people to God and each other.**
  - (9.) **Worship and Evangelism**
  - (10.) **Community Formation**
- **F. Serving and seeking the welfare of the city.**
  - (11.) **Justice and service**
  - (12.) **Integration of faith and work**

4. OUTWARD-FACING.

- **G. A missiological model for the church**
  - (13.) **A missiological ecclesiology (theory)**
  - (14.) **A missional congregation (practice)**
- **H. Contextualization**
  - (15.) **Contextualizing communication to central cities.**

(16.) **Contextualizing community to central cities.**

5. MOVEMENT-MINDED.

I. Globalization and church planting

(17.) **Continual church planting**

(18.) **Unity of Christians in the city**

J. Globalization and leadership development

(19.) **Gospel theology of leadership**

(20.) **Plan for Leadership development-globally and locally**

Part 2 – Statements of Faith

BRIEF STATEMENT OF FAITH FOR PARTNERS AND AFFILIATES

This is a brief statement of faith for those who we are training and supporting.

1. The Trinity.

We believe in one God, eternally existing in three equally divine Persons: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, who know, love, and glorify one another. This one true and living God, as infinitely perfect in his love as in his holiness, is the Creator of all things. Immortal and eternal, he perfectly and exhaustively knows the end from the beginning, sustains and sovereignly rules over all things.

2. Revelation.

God has graciously disclosed his existence and power in the created order, and has supremely revealed himself to fallen human beings in the person of his Son, the incarnate Word. Yet this God has also inspired the words preserved in the Scriptures, the sixty-six books of the Old and New Testaments. They alone constitute the verbally inspired Word of God, utterly authoritative and without error in the original writings, complete in its revelation of his will for salvation, clear and sufficient for all that God requires us to believe and do, and final in its authority over every domain of knowledge to which it speaks.

3. Creation and Fall.

We believe that God created human beings, male and female, in his own image. God declared the created order to be very good, and called human beings to serve as God's vice-regents to care for and cultivate creation, living in holy and devoted fellowship with their Maker.

We believe that Adam's fall into sin through Satan's temptation distorted that image and forfeited his original blessedness—for himself and all his progeny. As a result, all human beings are alienated from God, corrupted in every aspect of their being (e.g. physically, mentally, volitionally, emotionally, and spiritually) and condemned to death—apart from God's intervention. But we believe that from all eternity God determined in grace to redeem a people for himself and restore his fallen creation, to the praise of his glorious grace.

4. The redemption of Jesus Christ.

We believe that, moved by love and in obedience to his Father, the eternal Son became human, fully God and fully human being, one Person in two natures. The man Jesus, the promised Messiah of

Israel, was born of the virgin Mary. He perfectly lived a sinless life, performed miraculous signs, was crucified under Pontius Pilate, arose bodily from the dead on the third day, and ascended into heaven.

We believe that on the cross he bore the full penalty due us for our sins, making full satisfaction to God's justice in our behalf, reconciling to God all those who believe. Inasmuch as Jesus' obedience and satisfaction on our behalf was offered and accepted without regard for anything in us, this justification is only of free grace, so that both the justice and grace of God is glorified in the justification of sinners. We believe that by his resurrection Christ Jesus was vindicated by his Father, broke the power of death and defeated him who once had power over it, and brought everlasting life to all his people; by his ascension he has been forever exalted as Lord and has prepared a place for us to be with him. We believe that salvation is found in no one else, for there is no other name given under heaven by which we must be saved.

The gospel is the joyful news that through the work of Christ on our behalf, God by grace is rescues and draws men and women into fellowship with himself and one another, and restores creation where we will enjoy this fellowship forever.

5. The power of the Holy Spirit.
We believe that, sent by the Father and the Son, the Holy Spirit glorifies the Lord Jesus Christ, and is present with and in believers. He regenerates sinners and unites them with Christ, such that they are justified before God through faith alone. He renews and sanctifies believers as members of God's family, such that they are empowered for Christ-like living and service and receive his sovereignly distributed gifts.

6. The kingdom of God.
We believe that the kingdom of God, already present but not fully realized, is the exercise of God's invasive power in the world toward the eventual redemption of all creation. Those who have been saved by grace enter the kingdom and receive inward transformation that awakens a desire to glorify, trust, and obey God. Good works and holiness of life constitute indispensable evidence of saving grace. Recognizing whose created order this is, and because we are citizens of God's kingdom, we are to love our neighbors as ourselves, doing good to all. Believers must neither withdraw into seclusion from the world, nor become indistinguishable from it: rather, we are to do good to the whole city and seek its flourishing and prosperity.

7. The new community of believers.
We believe that the church is the people of God, the body of Christ, and the fellowship of the Spirit. It is both universal and yet manifested in local churches. Jesus has brought about not only peace with God, but peace between alienated peoples--his purpose was to create in himself one new humanity. The church serves as a sign of God's future new world when its members live for the service of one another and their neighbors, rather than for self-focus. We believe that baptism and the Lord's Supper are ordained by the Lord Jesus himself. The former is connected with entrance into the community, the latter with ongoing renewal. Together they are simultaneously God's

pledge to us, divinely ordained means of grace, our public vows of submission to the once crucified and now resurrected Christ, and anticipations of his return and of the consummation of all things.

8. The restoration of all things. We believe in the personal, glorious, and bodily return of our Lord Jesus Christ, when he will exercise his role as final Judge, and his kingdom will be consummated. We believe in the bodily resurrection of both the just and the unjust—the unjust to eternal punishment and the just to eternal blessedness in the presence of God. At that time God will bring about a new heavens and new earth. On the final day the whole creation will be purged from all the effects of sin. They will be forever banished and every tear will be wiped away.

Notes on the Brief Statement of Faith:
This document is not overtly Reformed. While Wesleyans, Pentecostals, and Lutherans, for example, would wish we added and affirmed things that are left unsaid, they and most other non-Reformed Protestants should be in full agreement on it. It also is specifically designed to include those of different ecclesiastical traditions—Episcopal, Presbyterian, Independent.

1. This paragraph is the classic statement of the Trinity. It specifically precludes the newer 'Openness of God' movement, in which God does not know the future and does not have control over what happens. The statement about ruling over all things does lean a bit in a Reformed direction, but Wesleyans and Pentecostals would certainly affirm it.

2. This paragraph makes clear that there is such a thing as common grace/natural revelation (versus those who are completely negative about involvement in the world.) It affirms a very high view of the Bible, stating that the Bible's very words are God's words, that none are in error or unauthoritative, and that the Bible is clear and sufficient enough for salvation and life in the world. It also adds that the Bible is authoritative not just in the private, 'spiritual' realm but over any area of life it addresses.

3. This paragraph leans Reformed—because it says that every single part of human nature is corrupted by sin and that we cannot choose God without intervention from him. Some Catholic and Protestant theologians have insisted that we have the ability in ourselves to turn to God, but many non-Reformed thinkers, including Wesley and Luther, would agree with this way of putting it. So the Statement of Faith has a Reformed 'cast' to it, but most non-Calvinists could affirm it.

4. The paragraph on Jesus gives the classic formulation of the person of Christ, and the classic view of penal substitutionary atonement and grace-justification accepted by historic Protestants—Reformed, Lutheran, Wesleyan. It concludes with the affirmation that Jesus is the only way of salvation.

5. The paragraph on the Holy Spirit and salvation is careful to point out that salvation happens through real union with Christ, and yet justification is not granted because of some infused righteousness (as Catholics and high-church teaching holds) but by faith alone.

6. This paragraph on the kingdom of God gives a basis for works of service in the world. It emphasizes the grace-basis for good deeds, and also the 'already but not yet' of God's renewal of the world. We are not utopian or hopeless about impact on our culture.

7. The paragraph on the church strikes a lot of balances, so that Episcopal, Presbyterian, Baptist, Congregational and independent churches can subscribe to it.

8. The paragraph on the consummation is lays out what orthodox Christians have believed about the final judgment. The second sentence doesn't preclude premillenial believers who think the resurrections to punishment and reward are at different times. The paragraph doesn't provide much cover for people who believe in 'annihilationism'—that the lost simply cease to exist.

A STATEMENT OF FAITH FOR REDEEMER GLOBAL

This would be the official statement of faith for board members and executive staff to affirm.

1. The Tri-une God

We believe in one God, eternally existing in three equally divine Persons: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, who know, love, and glorify one another. This one true and living God is as infinitely perfect in his love as in his holiness, is the Creator of all things, visible and invisible, and is therefore worthy to receive all glory and adoration. Immortal and eternal, he perfectly and exhaustively knows the end from the beginning, sustains and sovereignly rules over all things, and providentially brings about his eternal good purposes to redeem a people for himself and restore his fallen creation, to the praise of his glorious grace.

2. Revelation

God has graciously disclosed his existence and power in the created order, and has supremely revealed himself to fallen human beings in the person of his Son, the incarnate Word. Yet this God is a speaking God, and by his Spirit has graciously disclosed himself in human words: we believe that God has inspired the words preserved in the Scriptures, the sixty-six books of the Old and New Testaments, which are both record and means of his saving work in the world. These writings alone constitute the verbally inspired Word of God, utterly authoritative and without error in the original writings, complete in its revelation of his will for salvation, sufficient for all that God requires us to believe and do, and final in its authority over every domain of knowledge to which it speaks. We confess that both our finitude and our sinfulness preclude the possibility of knowing God's truth exhaustively, but we affirm that, enlightened by the Spirit of God, we can know God's revealed truth truly. The Bible is to be believed, as God's instruction, in all that it teaches; obeyed, as God's command, in all that it requires; and trusted, as God's pledge, in all that it promises. As God's people hear, believe, and do the Word, they are equipped as disciples of Christ and witnesses to the gospel.

3. Creation

We believe that God created human beings, male and female, in his own image. Adam and Eve belonged to the created order that God himself declared to be very good, serving as God's agents to care for, manage, and govern creation, living in holy and devoted fellowship with their Maker. Men

and women, equally made in the image of God, enjoy equal access to God by faith in Christ Jesus and are both called to move beyond passive self-indulgence to significant private and public engagement in family, church, and civic life.

Adam and Eve were made to complement each other in a one flesh union such that marriage ultimately serves as a type of the union between Christ and his church, and establishes the normative pattern of sexual relations between men and women. In God's wise purposes, they are not simply interchangeable, but rather they complement each other in mutually enriching ways. God ordains that they assume distinctive roles which reflect the loving relationship between Christ and the church, the husband exercising headship in a way that displays the caring, sacrificial love of Christ, and the wife submitting to her husband in a way that models the love of the church for her Lord. In the ministry of the church, both men and women are encouraged to serve Christ and to be developed to their full potential in the manifold ministries of the people of God. The distinctive leadership role within the church given to qualified men is grounded in creation, fall, and redemption and must not be sidelined by appeal to cultural developments.

4. The Fall

We believe that Adam's fall into sin through Satan's temptation distorted that image and forfeited his original blessedness—for himself and all his progeny. As a result, all human beings are alienated from God, corrupted in every aspect of their being (e.g. physically, mentally, volitionally, emotionally, spiritually) and condemned finally and irrevocably to death—apart from God's own gracious intervention. The supreme need of all human beings is to be reconciled to the God under whose just and holy wrath we stand; the only hope of all human beings is the undeserved love of this same God, who alone can rescue us and restore us to himself.

5. The Plan of God

We believe that from all eternity God determined in grace to save a great multitude of guilty sinners from every tribe and language and people and nation, and to this end foreknew them and chose them, that he justifies and sanctifies those who by grace have faith in Jesus, and that he will one day glorify them—all to the praise of his glorious grace. In love he commands and implores all people to repent and believe, having set his saving love on those he has chosen and having ordained Christ to be their Redeemer.

6. The Gospel

We believe that the gospel is the good news of Jesus Christ—God's very wisdom. Utter folly to the world, even though it is the power of God to those who are being saved, this good news is christological, centering on the cross and resurrection: the gospel is not proclaimed if Christ is not proclaimed, and the authentic Christ has not been proclaimed if his death and resurrection are not central (the message is "Christ died for our sins . . . [and] was raised"). This good news is biblical (his death and resurrection are according to the Scriptures), theological and salvific (Christ died for our sins, to reconcile us to God), historical (if the saving events did not happen, our faith is worthless, we are still in our sins, and we are to be pitied more than all others), apostolic (the message was entrusted to and transmitted by the apostles, who were witnesses of these saving events), and intensely personal (where it is received, believed, and held firmly, individual persons are saved).

7. The Redemption of Christ
We believe that, moved by love and in obedience to his Father, the eternal Son became human: the Word became flesh, fully God and fully human being, one Person in two natures. The man Jesus, the promised Messiah of Israel, was conceived through the miraculous agency of the Holy Spirit, and was born of the virgin Mary. He perfectly obeyed his heavenly Father, lived a sinless life, performed miraculous signs, was crucified under Pontius Pilate, arose bodily from the dead on the third day, and ascended into heaven. As the mediatorial King, he is seated at the right hand of God the Father, exercising in heaven and on earth all of God's sovereignty, and is our High Priest and righteous Advocate. We believe that by his incarnation, life, death, resurrection, and ascension, Jesus Christ acted as our representative and substitute, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God: on the cross he canceled sin, propitiated God, and, by bearing the full penalty of our sins, reconciled to God all those who believe. By his resurrection Christ Jesus was vindicated by his Father, broke the power of death and defeated him who once had power over it, and brought everlasting life to all his people; by his ascension he has been forever exalted as Lord and has prepared a place for us to be with him. We believe that salvation is found in no one else, for there is no other name given under heaven by which we must be saved. Because God chose the lowly things of this world, the despised things, the things that are not, to nullify the things that are, no human being can ever boast before him—Christ Jesus has become for us wisdom from God, that is, our righteousness, holiness, and redemption.

8. The Justification of Sinners
We believe that Christ, by his obedience and death, fully discharged the debt of all those who are justified. By his sacrifice, he bore in our stead the penalty due us, making a proper, real, and full satisfaction to God's justice in our behalf. Inasmuch as he was given by the Father for us, and his obedience and satisfaction accepted in our stead, and both freely and not for anything in us, this justification is only of free grace, in order that both the exact justice and the rich grace of God might be glorified in the justification of sinners.

9. The Power of the Holy Spirit
We believe that this salvation, attested in all Scripture and secured by Jesus Christ, is applied to his people by the Holy Spirit. Sent by the Father and the Son, the Holy Spirit glorifies the Lord Jesus Christ, and, as the "other" Paraclete, is present with and in believers. He convicts the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment, and by his powerful and mysterious work regenerates spiritually dead sinners, awakening them to repentance and faith, baptizing them into union with the Lord Jesus, such that they are justified before God by grace alone through faith alone in Jesus Christ alone. By his agency, believers are renewed, sanctified, and adopted into God's family; they participate in the divine nature and receive his sovereignly distributed gifts. The Holy Spirit is himself the downpayment of the promised inheritance, and in this age indwells, guides, instructs, equips, revives, and empowers believers for Christ-like living and service.

10. The Kingdom of God
We believe that those who have been saved by the grace of God through union with Christ by faith and through regeneration by the Holy Spirit enter the kingdom of God and delight in the blessings of the new covenant: the forgiveness of sins, the inward transformation that awakens a desire to

glorify, trust, and obey God, and the prospect of the glory yet to be revealed. Good works constitute indispensable evidence of saving grace. Living as salt in a world that is decaying and light in a world that is dark, believers must neither withdraw into seclusion from the world, nor become indistinguishable from it: rather, we are to do good to the city, for all the glory and honor of the nations is to be offered up to the living God. Recognizing whose created order this is, and because we are citizens of God's kingdom, we are to love our neighbors as ourselves, doing good to all, especially to those who belong to the household of God. The kingdom of God, already present but not fully realized, is the exercise of God's sovereignty in the world toward the eventual redemption of all creation. The kingdom of God is an invasive power that regenerates and renovates the lives of individuals through repentance and faith. It therefore inevitably establishes a new community of human life together under God.

11. God's New People

We believe that God's new covenant people have already come to the heavenly Jerusalem; they are already seated with Christ in the heavenlies. This universal church is manifest in local churches, of which Christ is the only Head; thus each "local church" is, in fact, the church, the household of God, the assembly of the living God, and the pillar and foundation of the truth. The church is the body of Christ, the apple of his eye, graven on his hands, and he has pledged himself to her forever. The church is distinguished by her gospel message, her sacred ordinances, her discipline, her great mission, and, above all, by her love for God, and by her members' love for one another and for the world. Crucially, this gospel we cherish has both personal and corporate dimensions, neither of which may properly be overlooked. Christ Jesus is our peace: not only has he brought about peace with God, but peace between alienated peoples. His purpose was to create in himself one new humanity, thus making peace, and in one body to reconcile both Jew and Gentile to God through the cross, by which he put to death their hostility. The church serves as a sign of God's future new world when its members live for the service of one another and their neighbors, rather than for self-focus. The church is the preeminent dwelling place of God's Spirit, and the continuing witness to God in the world.

12. Baptism and the Lord's Supper

We believe that baptism and the Lord's Supper are ordained by the Lord Jesus himself. The former is connected with entrance into the new covenant community, the latter with ongoing covenant renewal. Together they are simultaneously God's pledge to us, divinely ordained means of grace, our public vows of submission to the once crucified and now resurrected Christ, and anticipations of his return and of the consummation of all things.

13. The Restoration of All Things

We believe in the personal, glorious, and bodily return of our Lord Jesus Christ with his holy angels, when he will exercise his role as final Judge, and his kingdom will be consummated. We believe in the bodily resurrection of both the just and the unjust—the unjust to judgment and eternal conscious punishment in hell, as our Lord himself taught, and the just to eternal blessedness in the presence of him who sits on the throne and of the Lamb, in the new heaven and the new earth, the home of righteousness. On that day the church will be presented faultless before God by the merits and triumph of Christ, all sin purged and its wretched effects forever banished. God will be all in all and

his people will be enthralled by the immediacy of his ineffable holiness, and everything will be to the praise of his glorious grace.

Notes on the Statement of Faith for Redeemer Global

This document was developed by Tim Keller and Don Carson in process with a group of over 60 evangelical pastors. It was designed to put forth a Reformed affirmation of faith but which uses few of the traditional historic theological concepts found in those creeds. Rather, it is a fresh statement, employing Biblical phrases and terminology. It is deliberately inclusive of Episcopal, Presbyterian, and Baptist ecclesiology. It is also careful (in paragraph #3 to talk about male headship in home and church, but to leave it to churches and ministries how that it expressed. For example, evangelicals like John Stott, who allow women priests but not women bishops, would be included by this statement.

Appendix A – What is the Gospel?

The gospel is the joyful news that through the work of Christ on our behalf, God by grace is rescues and draws men and women into fellowship with himself and one another, and restores creation where we will enjoy this fellowship forever.

1. The Gospel's Character

a. The gospel is news about the historical events of Jesus' life. The word 'gospel' means news of a world-changing historical event and how you should respond to it. *Mark 1:1; Luke 2:10*-The gospel is the birth, life, death, and resurrection of Jesus. *1 Cor 1:16-17*-The gospel is Jesus' death on the cross. *1 Cor 15:1-10-* The gospel is that Jesus died on the cross for us and was raised from the dead for us, according the Scriptures, so that even the worst sinners can be saved by grace.

b. The gospel is a power, a living thing that brings joy and changes lives. *Rom 1:16-17*-The gospel does not just have power but *is* God's power to save in verbal form. *1 Cor 4:15; 1 Peter 1:23-35; Col 1:5-6*-The gospel is a living thing that brings people to new birth and life. *2 Cor 4:4 (and context)*-The gospel gives us <u>now</u> the light of the divine glory in the face of the Lord. This is an access to God's presence that Moses was forbidden (Exod 33) but now is ours through Christ (cf. John 1:18.)

c. The gospel is truth, with definite doctrinal content. *Gal 1:6,11-* The gospel was not invented by humans. If even Paul gives you a different gospel, don't listen to him! *Gal 2:5*-Heresy endangers the gospel, which must be preserved at all costs. *Phil 1:16-* A person's mind must be persuaded of the truth of the gospel. *Col 1:23*-The gospel is truth for the whole world, not just for some. *Eph 1:13-* The gospel is the word of truth

d. The gospel is eternally, infinitely deep. *1 Peter 2:12 (and context)*-The angels never tire of looking into and exploring the gospel. It is endlessly rich and deep. *1 Peter 1:25*-The gospel is eternal.

2. The Gospel's Content

a. The gospel is a "Third Way" of grace between religion and irreligion. *Romans 1-3-* Neither religious Jews nor pagan Gentiles can be justified. The gospel is we are saved by grace through Christ's work, not ours. *Acts 10:36*-The gospel gives us new peace with God—the alienation if over. Acts 20:24- The gospel is the word of *grace. Col 1:5-6-* To believe the gospel is to understand the grace of God in all its truth.

b. The gospel is not just about God's grace, but about God's grace restoring creation.
Rom 2:16-The gospel includes Jesus' return to judge and renew the earth. *Acts 13:32; Eph 3:6-* All the promises of God to restore the world through Israel have come true in Jesus. *Mark 1:14-15; Lk 8:1;16:16 -* The gospel is news of the coming kingdom, the new age of God's reign that brings restoration and healing. *Mark 4:23; 9:35;Luke 9:6-* Jesus healed and fed while preaching the gospel—these were foretastes of the coming restoration.

c. The gospel demands a response. *Acts 14:15*-The gospel calls you to turn away from idols to the living God (repent.) *Acts 8:12*-It also calls you to believe .*Mk 1:15*-The gospel requirements of repenting and believing are mentioned together. *Rom10:16; 2Thess 1:8; 1Peter 4:17*-Sometimes these two are combined in the term *obey the gospel,* meaning to both repent and believe. *1 Thess 1:5-* Repentance and faith requires the full conviction that is produced by the Holy Spirit.

3. The Gospel's Comprehensiveness

a. The gospel is the foundation for everything in the Christian life. *Rom 15:20*-The gospel is the basis for all individual and corporate Christian living. To preach the gospel equals laying the foundation.

b. The gospel is how we continue to grow individually. *Rom 16:25-* The gospel does not only save but continues to spiritually strengthen. *Gal 3:1-3-* You do not only become a Christian through the gospel, but

you also grow into Christ-likeness more and more through more deeply understanding and practicing the implications of the gospel. *Mark 8:35*-You must 'lose your life' for the sake of the gospel. The deeper the grasp of grace, the greater the willing surrender of life control to Jesus. *2 Cor 9:13*- Generosity comes from the humility that flows from the on-going confession of the gospel. *2 Cor 8:8-9* – Sacrificial service to others is not so much a legal requirement as a response to the free grace of Jesus in the gospel. *Gal 2:14*- Racist attitudes come from not living in line with the truth of the gospel. The behavioral implications and new motivations that flow from the gospel are to be worked out into every area of life.

c. The gospel is basis for new community. The gospel is not only re-shapes every part of our individual lives, but every part of our communal life together. *Matt 4:23;11:1-5; Luke 4:18-6:20-35*- The gospel of the kingdom is a new social arrangement within the Christian community that is a foretaste of the future new world. The poor, broken-hearted, unrecognized, oppressed have pride of place, and the powerful and wealthy are humbled. *Phil.1:27*-We are to conduct the entire course of our life in the world (citizenship-*politeuma*) in way worthy of gospel.

d. The gospel must be communicated. *Act 5:42*-To preach Jesus is to preach the gospel. *Acts 8:4*- Every Christian is to communicate the gospel. *Phil1:7*-The gospel must be defended (*apologia*) persuasively. *Phil 1:12: Eph 6:19; Col 1:23*--We advance the gospel through preaching.